

Reflective Reading Assignment #1:

Pippin Barr - What Stuff Games Are Made Of, Chapter 2

CART 315

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September 17th 2026

One thing I kept thinking about while reading Barr's chapter was how much my own relationship with games probably affects the games I make. I have always thought a good game needs clear rules because they guide the player toward what the designer wants them to do. I also like having something to work toward because, personally, I have a hard time making my own fun out of nothing. If a game does not give me much to do, I usually do not want to spend my time clicking around trying to figure out what I am supposed to find interesting. Because of this, I have never really thought about the possibility that simply sitting with a game's material could be part of the experience. Barr's examples of changing the rules of Pong made me realize that players can create their own meaning or enjoyment from a system, even when the game is not directly telling them what to do. *Trace Pong* especially stood out to me because the players are still playing Pong, but their actions also create a temporary drawing. The game becomes something to look at and experience rather than just something to win.

This made me wonder if some of my own games end up feeling a little flat because I design from my own habits and preferences as a player. I tend to want to be directed or prompted, so maybe I naturally put more structure into my games. Barr's idea of asking "What if?" made me think about giving players more room to explore instead of always deciding what they should be doing.

I do not think my preference for structure is necessarily bad, but I am realizing that it is only one way of experiencing a game. Maybe part of becoming a better designer is learning to make space for types of play that I would not naturally seek out myself.

Word Count: 318